CORTEX MOMENTUM // ONE-PAGE CROSS-MARKET READ

Four energy threads, 2026 so far, and where each stands

Deep-tech and other energy markets · as of October 2026 · a dated snapshot, not a forecast

Across large loads, storage, solar and firm power, the binding constraint this year wasn't the technology or its cost. It was the rule that decides who gets paid, who pays, and whose date counts.

THE PATTERN ACROSS ALL FOUR

I write a short read every week on the energy signals that matter commercially. Since April, four topics kept coming back. Read together, they make one point: in 2026, hardware stopped being the constraint. Batteries are cheap, panels are a small share of installed cost, and turbines and transformers are scarce but well understood. What decided outcomes was a rule or a date:

- whether a market rule pays for what an asset does;
- whether a tariff or contract decides who carries a cost;
- whether a compliance file holds up under a credit buyer's diligence;
- whether a delivery date can be held.

If you sell into any of these markets, the question your buyer is really asking is usually one of those four.

THE FOUR THREADS

- **Large loads: who pays and who gets connected.** In the spring, the fight was over who pays for the wires. **Watch:** FERC's ruling on PJM's October 29 backstop refiling and the early-December capacity auction.
- **Storage economics: what actually gets paid for.** Storage gets built where a rule pays for speed, duration or availability, and stalls where it doesn't, even with cheap cells. **Watch:** Britain's final long-duration awards and Spain's first capacity auction.
- **Solar after subsidies: the panel is solved, the paperwork isn't.** With modules near commodity prices and US credits now running down to a 2030 edge, solar's margin moved to three places: proving compliance to the credit buyer, delivering power in hours an offtaker will pay for, and getting permitted and connected faster than the next project. **Watch:** the December 4 import price floors and the first full quarter after the July 4 construction deadline.
- **Firm power under bottlenecks.** With firm capacity and its equipment both booked years out, the market buys on delivery date, not lifetime cost. **Watch:** whether turbine reservations keep converting to orders, and whether federal retirement overrides survive in court.

QUESTIONS TO WATCH, SCORED IN OUR JANUARY UPDATE

- **December 2026 to March 2027:** what does PJM's 2029/30 base capacity auction clear at in early December, and does FERC accept PJM's October 29 backstop refiling, which charges costs to the zones where large loads are growing, before bidding opens March 1?
- **By December 31, 2026:** do Ofgem's final cap-and-floor awards confirm the 16 shortlisted long-duration projects on the minded-to terms?
- **December 4, 2026 onward:** do US module prices move toward the new $0.38/W import floor in the first solar market report of 2027 (expected around March)?
- **Late January 2027:** does GE Vernova's gas backlog plus reservations reach its guided 130 GW, with conversions still outpacing new reservations?
- **By March 31, 2027:** does PJM refile a curtail-first framework, or does a large PJM state set curtailment priority for large loads?

If this bears on a decision you're making. A 30-minute call is for one thing: you bring the decision and its date, and we'll tell you what this read changes about it, and what it can't tell you. If the honest answer is that you don't need us, we'll say so. Book at **cortexmomentum.com**.

Cortex Momentum is an energy and cleantech market-intelligence advisory. The full read, with dated posts and sources: **cortexmomentum.com/interconnect**.

Each thread page is a dated snapshot of my own read, not a forecast. It cites my LinkedIn posts by date, and public sources for where things stand. Engagement on those posts is attention, not demand: it shows what people argued with, not what anyone will buy. Sources were checked in October 2026, and on the large-loads page in November.